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COL-800805

Accompanied by the faint glow of an arcane skill, an ambitious guest has come to visit the world inside the suitcase.

Eternity: Welcome, my esteemed guest.

Ms. NewBabel: Nice to meet you, Ms. Winnifred, Ms. Vertin. I have to say, this land is even more magical and imaginative than I'd expected.

Ms. NewBabel: Yes. The sunlight and air are quite ideal. The children are going to love it here.

Ms. NewBabel: Ahem, Loretta, sit down. Stop circling our guest.

Ms. NewBabel: My apologies, Ms. Vertin.

Vertin: It's alright. I think she's just curious.

Eternity: Ms. Vertin is also quite interested in your children, Ms. NewBabel.

Ms. NewBabel: Of course, of course. I'd be happy to introduce you to them. Which should we start with? Arnold, Heather, Pamela ...?

A figure in green suddenly pounces in from outside the hall.

Sotheby: You little rascal, I knew you were hiding here!

Ms. NewBabel: Hm? Hello, little lady.

Sotheby: Ah! I'm ever so sorry, ladies. I didn't know you were having a tea party.

She hastily curtsies to them and turns tail before finally remembering her current mission.

Sotheby: Oh right! Ladies, have you seen a strange critter at all?

Ms. NewBabel: Heh heh. I think I know who you're looking for.

Out in the Wilderness, lively, sticky, fluffy, and scratchy critters are creating a commotion.

Sotheby: Huh? There weren't this many critters here a moment ago! Ah! Bad friends! That's Mr. Rabies's straw!

Desert Flannel: This wasn't in the job description. See, this is why I said we should be promoting electronic pets!

Desert Flannel props up the shrubs and saplings that have been knocked down by the critters.

Medicine Pocket: Aghh! Damn critters! You think you're a match for my teeth?!

Eternity: Ms. NewBabel, were your children always this ... fond of exercise?

Ms. NewBabel: Not usually. They're lively, but they know how to keep it under control. I wonder what's going on ...

The clock tower chimes. Ms. NewBabel looks up as a gentle rain of fresh Dust falls from it.

The Cruzan family's arcane skill is remarkably effective.

The critter's wild partying abruptly stops as Ms. NewBabel starts chanting, finally giving the unwilling guests a moment to catch their breaths.

[English text unavailable]

COL-800806

Vertin: Thank you for putting an end to the chaos, Ms. NewBabel.

Ms. NewBabel: I'm the one who should apologize, Ms. Vertin. I should've noticed the children's abnormalities sooner.

Ms. NewBabel: But, in my defense, this isn't an entirely bad thing. At least there's a "business opportunity" to be found here.

Vertin: Business opportunity?

Ms. NewBabel: How do you intend to handle these little troublemakers?

Vertin: I'm not sure yet. I think I'll have to apply for some resettlement funds from the Foundation first.

Ms. NewBabel: No need to go through all that trouble, dear.

Ms. NewBabel: They aren't hopeless destroyers; they just need some proper guidance. I can influence their behavior patterns with my arcane skill and boost a few production methods, too.

Vertin: Guidance?

Ms. NewBabel: Exactly. We can teach them to channel their pent-up energy into work, engaging in production, or cultivating sections of the Wilderness.

Ms. NewBabel: See this as my first gift to you—a mutually beneficial solution, Ms. Vertin.

Ms. NewBabel: Let's move somewhere quieter to discuss the details.

Ms. NewBabel: Critters are very useful creatures. They can help us produce all kinds of things that will benefit all kinds of people.

Ms. NewBabel: They're not terrifying monsters—they're friends in a different form.

Ms. NewBabel: Just think. If we do this, people from all over the world will come to understand critters, rather than hate them.

Ms. NewBabel: Eventually, they could even join thousands of households, just like any ordinary pet.

Vertin: It sounds like a feasible plan.

Ms. NewBabel: I'm glad you think so, dear. I believe we can start a test run here, on our patch of the Wilderness.

Vertin: We'll need to come up with a name for this concept.

Vertin: Let's use your current company name, Ms. NewBabel's Critter Rehabilitation Center.

Ms. NewBabel bows slightly, and the critter at her feet gives a soft whimper.

Ms. NewBabel: I won't forget your kindness, dear.

The businesswoman straightens up, claps her hands, and gives a confident smile.

Ms. NewBabel: Now, let's get down to business. We have a company to run.

[English text unavailable]

COL-800807

Thirty-seven: All living creatures ought to belong to some set. Hmm, strange! Why do your numbers look so chaotic?

Critter: Nee—blegh—

Thirty-seven: Don't run! I just need to calculate a few formulas. It won't take long!

Vertin: 37, you've scared it.

Thirty-seven: They're different from the critters on the island. Perhaps new formulas need to be introduced to prove them.

The critter whimpers before quickly fleeing in another direction.

Medicine Pocket: Don't move, you furry little rascal! Now, let's see ...

Vertin: What are you doing?

Medicine Pocket swivels around, holding a Solidus in one hand and a trembling Carbuncle in the other, its eyes wide with fear.

Medicine Pocket: Isn't it obvious? These guys are challenging my expertise in biting. I've gotta study their mechanisms of force and chewing intensity as soon as possible.

Vertin: Carbuncles ... eat Solidus, too?

Medicine Pocket: This is research, got it!? Besides, it took me ages to snatch this from Centurion. Hey! That's my experimental material! Give it back!

Desert Flannel: Look at this poor little guy! You didn't sign a consent to experimentation form, did you?

Ms. NewBabel: Oh, it seems our little Pamela has made some new friends.

Medicine Pocket: You're welcome. I'll send you a copy of my experimental data as well.

Desert Flannel: Ms. NewBabel, say I need a critter to help distribute flyers. Would this little one be able to assist me?

Ms. NewBabel: I'd be more than happy to extend the invitation. But the decision rests with little Pamela.

Ms. NewBabel: Give her some time. She needs calm more than anything right now.

The two mutter as they leave, and little Pamela hides once more at her owner's feet.

Vertin: Sorry, the critters in the suitcase have quite different personalities. I hope it isn't too bothersome.

Ms. NewBabel: Heh heh, that's normal. The little ones are the same. They just need a bit of time to understand one another.

Ms. NewBabel: Besides, they're providing me with great material for my future projects—"The Arcanists and Ms. NewBabel's Mutant Critters" for example.

Vertin: Your ambition is admirable, Ms. NewBabel.

Ms. NewBabel: So, we've already figured out how they operate and managed to produce a suitable batch of products ...

Ms. NewBabel: Next is to expand—set up some production lines, and increase publicity ...

Vertin: Aren't you going to take a break?

Ms. NewBabel: Of course not. Time waits for no one, my dear—a lesson I've learned many times.

Ms. NewBabel: There's far too much to do to take a break.

Ms. NewBabel: Think you can keep up, business partner?

Vertin: Of course.

[English text unavailable]

COL-8oo8o8

Medicine Pocket: You ate my glove!? How about some reagent? Damn it! Where did all these critters come from?

X: Calm down, Medicine Pocket.

X: You've been here for a while now; shouldn't you be used to the chaos around here? Oh, sorry, I forgot that it's usually you causing the chaos around Laplace.

Medicine Pocket: Oh, they're gonna tear this place apart! Gnawing away at the door panels, crunching up the asphalt and cement, setting the lawn on fire ... I'm excited!

Ms. NewBabel: I'm glad to see you're so lively.

Ms. NewBabel: But, my dear children, don't forget your proper social etiquette, alright?

Her arcane skill shines again, and the critters' enthusiasm temporarily subsides.

X: They seem to be quickly adapting to life in the Wilderness. But have you considered the other issues that may arise, Ms. NewBabel?

Ms. NewBabel: Territorial disputes, resource competition, settlement forming ... then, of course, the irrepressible instinct to breed.

Ms. NewBabel: I fully understand your concerns, Mr. X. In fact, I've been thinking a lot about these issues.

The lady sighs and shakes her head helplessly.

X: What I mean to say is I can help you.

X: That is, if you're willing to provide me with some energetic volunteers for my new invention.

Ms. NewBabel: What exactly do you plan to do?

X: It's simple: we need a Cranking Gumball Machine! Turn the crank, and you'll get critter candies with various unique flavors.

X: The candy will attract different kinds of critters, and, more importantly, the critters will eat the candy rather than chew on the lawn.

X: Rest assured, these candies won't harm the critters! In fact, they'll provide them with richer nutrition.

Ms. NewBabel: It can control the quantity, improve quality, and achieve scalable, automated production ...

Ms. NewBabel: I don't see why we can't give it a try.

X: The only drawback, of course, is that it hasn't been invented yet.

Ms. NewBabel: ...

X: Mutual assistance, my friend!

X: You provide me with a batch of energetic critter volunteers for me to analyze so that I can prepare candies tailored to different critters.

X: And I provide you with a fully-functioning Cranking Gumball Machine.

Ms. NewBabel: I didn't expect you to have such a profound understanding of critters.

The sharp-eyed businesswoman sizes X up with interest.

X: Well, I don't exactly ...

X: I have to admit, a certain butterfly has provided substantial assistance in this research—knowledge, inspiration, and ... a touch of mischief.

He sighs as if unwilling to talk about her further.

Ms. NewBabel: Alright, I look forward to working with you, Mr. X.

She offers a warm handshake.

[English text unavailable]

COL-800809

Ms. NewBabel: A steady quarter. Order numbers are as expected; income's stable. No real surprises.

Ms. NewBabel: The Critter Rehabilitation Center has safely completed its first quarter. That proves that the business has a solid foundation. Now we need innovation to really grow our revenue.

Sotheby: Ms. NewBabel, your office printer went "thud, thud, thud" this morning and printed out three orders!

Sotheby: Is it time for another meeting? Everyone gathered together with no refreshments, no balls or balloons—just piles and piles of paper?

Ms. NewBabel: Good memory. Today's the day for our quarterly review. And while there won't be a ball, we have prepared plenty of refreshments.

Sotheby: I'm looking forward to it, Ms. NewBabel!

Ms. NewBabel: Of course, as soon as we finish the meeting, we can spend the rest of the time enjoying our tea.

She gently pats Sotheby on the head before handing her the documents.

Sotheby: Huh? Is this the plan? Wow! This is quite a lot of papers!

The Critter Rehabilitation Center's quarterly meeting is held as scheduled.

Everyone gathers to hear the results of the first quarter, with the speaker outlining its direction in simple strokes.

Ms. NewBabel: Based on the first quarter's revenue performance, I've devised a business plan to usher in a new era for the company.

Ms. NewBabel: But for now, rather than explaining the specifics, I'd like to talk about something more heartfelt—about the Critter Rehabilitation Center ...

Just then, a commotion interrupts the meeting.

A Carbuncle—a cultivated and well-trained employee—pokes its head in from the entrance.

It hops in place twice, feeling apologetic for its abruptness.

This is a signal—a sign that something big is about to happen.

Sotheby: Look! What's that in the critter's mouth?!

Sotheby: Oh my, that's a very long order slip indeed! Did it drag that all the way from the printer?!

A stream of "white snowflakes" floats in from outside.

Ms. NewBabel: It seems we may need to revise our revenue targets.

[English text unavailable]

COL-800810

Barbara: One ... two little black clouds, do you have time for an interview now?

The lively and polite Carbuncle tilts its head, silent.

Barbara: *sigh* It seems the critters here are no different from the ones outside.

X: Not at all, Ms. Barbara.

X: Our critter friends can participate in basic potion tests, soil analysis, and simple tilling. Their job prospects are quite broad.

Barbara: Oh, my, that's impressive! If only I could understand their language, then I could conduct an in-depth interview with them.

As Ms. Barbara expresses her admiration, a "clever" critter leaps toward Vertin's hat.

Sotheby: Hey, wait—! Mr. Critter, you can't sleep up there!

Vertin: Sorry, that's not a suitable place for you to stay.

Barbara: ...?

X: Ahem, let's forget about this matter, shall we?

"The personalities of the critters inside the suitcase are quite elusive and require further interview and investigation."

Barbara jots this down in her notebook.

Before long, a report on the critters of the Wilderness has spread far and wide, and the domesticated Carbuncles have drawn significant attention from the arcane community.

Ms. NewBabel: We need to schedule regular media days every week. Right now, our biggest shortage is manpower, followed by promotional meetings.

Sotheby: Ms. NewBabel! The order printer is overwhelmed; there are simply too many of them!

Ms. NewBabel: Don't worry, my dear. X has provided us with a batch of Constant Running Paperless Printers, ready for immediate use.

Sotheby: Oh, excellent! And ... Ms. NewBabel, there's one other thing, isn't there?

Ms. NewBabel: 7:30 p.m. in the garden—we're watching the premiere of "Ms. NewBabel" together. Is that it?

Ms. NewBabel: It's written down in my schedule.

Music echoes through the garden. Tonight's show holds a special significance. Although the critters still don't understand why they can see themselves projected on that big white sheet.

Ms. NewBabel: Thank you all! The critters have emerged from the Wilderness and are really making a difference to the world.

Ms. NewBabel: Hmm. I think we should add more hotline numbers.

[English text unavailable]

COL-800811

Sotheby: Cake, balloons, Dr. Papper, and a super-sized gift box! Yay! It's been so long since I had a party!

Medicine Pocket: Huh? Don't touch that; it's not a real gift box. Ugh, too late—you've already touched it.

Ms. NewBabel: No need to worry. Ms. Sotheby knows how to calm down those critters.

Medicine Pocket: You think I care about comforting a critter?

Medicine Pocket: I'd rather have a critter chew stick. At least that would ease my gum pain.

Ms. NewBabel: Heh heh, looks like I've selected the perfect prizes for this party.

Medicine Pocket: Just to be clear, you did promise me I could use the data from these little rascals in my experimental report, right?! It's not exactly easy to get funding for this kind of stuff.

Ms. NewBabel: Of course. I'm looking forward to the conclusions of your experiments, too, you know.

The adults chat away happily. As do the children.

Sotheby: Ms. NewBabel, look! This Carbuncle keeps rubbing against the feather on my hat.

Sotheby: Perhaps it wants to learn how to be a proper young lady! Can I give it one of the hats from my wardrobe?

X: Of course, you can! You can even apply some of my Automatic Teasing Lipstick on it.

Medicine Pocket: Quit pushing your weird inventions!

More and more critters are drawn to the commotion.

Sotheby: Huh? How did a Dodough get here? Ooh, your feathers are so warm! I suppose after listening to twenty-three chapters of Typhon and the Pegasus, you finally want to be friends with Typhon, don't you?

Vertin: Ms. NewBabel, it seems the Dodough is holding a letter for you.

Ms. NewBabel: Let me see. It appears to be from ... Professor Musae III?

Ms. NewBabel: "Dear child, I hear your company is progressing well, and as your teacher, I am very proud of you."

Ms. NewBabel: "That being said, don't forget to leave a little counter for me in a corner of your company, just in case my guests also grow fond of this place."

Ms. NewBabel: "Fluffy cushions, delicious orange juice ... Musae III is never short of fun and tasty things."

Ms. NewBabel: Of course, Professor. I'll be sure to do that.

[English text unavailable]

COL-800812

Enigma: Damn it, that hurts!

Ms. NewBabel: My apologies. The little ones had no intention of harming you; they just got over excited—being in a new environment and all.

Enigma: Critters? Research? Was I bitten by a critter, or have I been in this wretched place so long that I've started hallucinating?

Ms. NewBabel: I can assure you, they'll leave as soon as the Critter Rehabilitation Center seminar is over.

Enigma shrugs helplessly.

Enigma: Don't worry about it. It's not like our "great and pragmatic" institution can get any worse.

Ms. NewBabel: Have you run into some trouble? Things seem to be pretty hectic here.

Enigma: Trouble? Of course. There's so much trouble here that the word has lost all meaning.

X proudly joins their conversation.

X: Of course, there's trouble. They're spraying my Serial Killer Insecticide I invented last year.

Enigma: Not you again. By the way, regarding your Random Fruit-Shooting Alarm Clock development plan you mentioned three days ago, I refuse to participate.

X: Oh, that's a shame. What about the work on the Pest Entity Scare Machine?

Ms. NewBabel: Maybe I can lend a hand.

Ms. NewBabel rarely misses an opportunity to do business.

Enigma: So, this is the machine you want funding for?

Ms. NewBabel: Simply put, this machine can capture any critter you desire according to your needs.

Laplace Staff Member I: How about a critter that deciphers codes? Can it get me one of those?

Laplace Staff Member II: You don't actually believe this thing'll work, do you? This looks just like the Bubble Gum Shooting Alarm Clock X made a while ago. It's just a gumball machine filled with tasteless candy, isn't it?

Ms. NewBabel: Actually, I'd recommend you try it yourself. Go on, see what kind of creature you can attract with this machine.

Laplace Staff Member II: I hope this isn't some kind of prank.

The staff member impatiently pats the "head" of the machine.

Laplace Staff Member II: Wait—why is there smoke rising inside? It's swelling and shaking! And what's with that orange juice smell? Agh, my eyes!

Laplace Staff Member II: Damn, orange juice! It stings! X, Enigma, get that thing out of here, quick!

A thick cloud of smoke fills the area.

X: Ahem, it's only a prototype. A little lenience would be fair, right?

Ignoring the commotion, a brightly colored Carbuncle emerges from the smoke.

Enigma: How many bizarre creatures does this damned place still have hidden away?!

Laplace Staff Member II: Wait, Enigma! This seems to be an exceptionally rare species—the kind mentioned as "potentially existing" in Mr. Alger's paper!

X: See? This is of great scientific value.

Laplace Staff Member II: X, you have my full support in the development of your invention! I've been aching to dive into critter research for quite some time.

Enigma: ...

X: Everything happens for a reason, don't you think, Mr. Enigma?

[English text unavailable]

COL-800813

Sotheby: Ms. Vertin, Ms. NewBabel, thank you ever so much for the invitation. I simply adored "Carbuncle in the Courtyard"!

Sotheby: Don't you think that Typhon would surely become friends with the Carbuncle? Then they could throw a ball in the Auto Island!

Matilda: You said the exact same thing the day the Café Hangout opened, Ms. Sotheby!

Sotheby: So, why don't you film the next one in my Auto Island? I can cover all the expenses!

Matilda: Hmph, balls, critter friends, movie sequels—it all sounds utterly tasteless! I-I certainly will not attend!

Sotheby: We should invite Ms. Vertin, Ms. NewBabel, Mr. X, and ... Oh! Ms. Sonetto! I'm sure we can host the most spectacular and amazing ball they've ever attended!

Matilda: Wait—ahem! Even though I don't plan to attend the party, as Monitor Assistant at the SPDM, I must be present to supervise the event!

Sotheby: Hooray!

Ms. NewBabel: Ms. Sotheby, thank you for your kind offer. But I already have an idea for the sequel's filming location. Want to hear it?

Sotheby: Hmm?

Ms. NewBabel: Mr. Enigma told me that Laplace has developed a new interest in critter research. As it turns out, they're also willing to provide a venue and funding for the film.

X: Ah, it seems our research has piqued a lot of people's interests, my friend. A certain butterfly also plans to increase her investments in our research.

Ms. NewBabel: We're riding the wave, Mr. X.

Sotheby interrupts them, curiosity in her eyes.

Sotheby: So, Ms. NewBabel, where exactly is the filming location you mentioned? Is it at Glass Heads' house?

Ms. NewBabel: I'm afraid not. Ms. Vertin has offered us a more suitable place than Laplace.

Ms. NewBabel: I think you're going to like it.

Vertin: To convince the SPDM that a Teakettler could serve as a library guide, we've set the first stop of the "Ms. NewBabel" tour there.

Vertin: As Ms. NewBabel's special guest, I will also attend.

Sotheby: The library? Hooray! That will make it easier for everyone to find information!

Sotheby: Thank you, Ms. Vertin and Ms. NewBabel!

Ms. NewBabel: Another successful collaboration, don't you agree?

Vertin: Of course.

Ms. NewBabel: When the time comes, I'll send out the invitations for the sequel's premiere. One day "Ms. NewBabel" will enter every household in the world!